

Photo Courtesy TEJINDER SINGH

pared. 'It's not like what you did earlier...One, it's Bollywood, and, two, it's Kareena'. That's when the whole responsibility of it started sinking in. I felt Hansal sir had taken a punt on me for a key role in a key movie for him. I just had to deliver."

The main motivation of Daljeet, his character in TBM, comes from being a father. Did he tap into his own experience of fatherhood with son Ishaan? "Daljeet is a complex character, he has layers of grief, angst, anger, frustration, loss. His love for his son is the only anchoring emotion he has. For me to get the love right was very, very important," says Brar.

How was it to get into the skin of another person? "See, there are a lot of advantages that come with having done television for so long. You're not intimidated by cameras and crews anymore," says the actor. Even so, he shares that the journey into acting was a tentative one. He was initially offered only negative characters in south Indian movies in 2017-18, which he rejected.

It was *Modern Love Mumbai* that made Brar more open to the idea of acting. "That gave me a lot of confidence. As a chef, you're always observing people. With MLM, there was a sense of comfort, since I was playing a chef. And there was a sense of discomfort too, as I was playing an LGBTQ+ character. So, I think that balance of comfort and discomfort gave me a good window to explore...get cajoled into this profession and get the confidence to play a strong grey character," he divulges. While he's still got his hands full with family and his restaurant Kashkan in Dubai and others in the US, Brar hopes to make time for one or two acting projects a year.

Brar admits, though, "Whenever the camera rolls, I'm very used to being Ranveer. So, I've had to break that pattern and be the character. The ability to just shut off Ranveer for a few weeks is what I look forward to in my acting projects," he grins. ■

–Priya Pathiyan

Patel, who is stranded on a lifeboat in the Pacific Ocean with a hyena, an orangutan, a zebra and a Royal Bengal Tiger named Richard Parker. Over 200 days adrift, Pi embarks on an extraordinary journey of survival, resilience and self-discovery amidst a gripping tale of beauty and brutality.

Max Webster, the visionary director, reflects on the challenges of bringing such a visually rich story to the stage. "The story of *Life of Pi* is a heart-stopping tale of survival that looks like it would be impossible to stage, but I like staging the impossible," he shares.

A highlight of the production is its lifelike puppetry, especially for Richard Parker. Webster elaborates, "When we began, we didn't know how to create the animals. But when Finn Caldwell and Nick Barnes, our puppet directors, made a prototype tiger, there was no turning back." The tiger's realism is achieved using three puppeteers in a technique inspired by Bunraku theatre. "The staging is so meticulously choreographed that the audience believes they are watching a tiger on a boat lost at sea," he adds.

Staged at the NMACC's Grand Theatre, the production benefits from cutting-edge technology, including Dolby Atmos Surround Sound, multidimensional lighting enhanced by Swarovski crystals, and an ingenious seating arrangement that ensures every spectator experiences the full spectacle.

LIFE OF PI is on at the NMACC in Mumbai from December 5 to 22, 2024

Life of Pi has garnered numerous accolades, including five Olivier Awards and three Tony Awards. Its universal themes resonate deeply with audiences. "The story is metaphorically open, allowing people to connect with it in different ways, inviting multiple interpretations," Webster observes.

Nita M. Ambani, founder and chairperson of NMACC, is also excited about the production coming to India, saying it underscores the Centre's mission to promote Indian and global art. "I hope our spaces inspire talent and bring communities together," she shares. ■

–Nikhil Sardana